COMING OF AGE: A LOOK AT 2ND GENERATION AND U.S.-BORN YOUNG ADULTS' VIEWS OF THEIR FAMILIES



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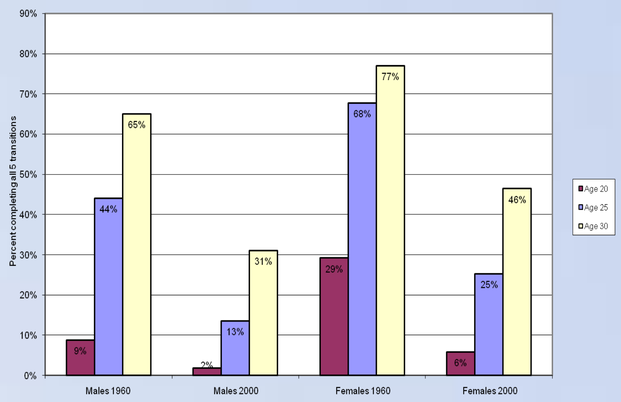
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Introduction

- Transition to adulthood previously occurred immediately following adolescence, today young adults take longer to leave home, complete school, enter the workforce, get married and have children (see Figure 1)
- Due to the prolonged transition, parents have stepped in to bridge their children's transition to adulthood
- This is a fairly new field, with most of the current research based on white middle class young adults, failing to capture the experiences of young adult immigrants
- This study looks at how Black and White 2nd generation young adults view the role of their families in their transition to adulthood compared with their Black and White US-born counterparts

Figure 1. Completing the Adult Transition in 1960 and 2000
Leaving home, finishing school, becoming financially independent, getting married, and having a child



Data are from the Integrated Public Use Microdata Series extracts (IPUMS) of the 1960 and 2000 U.S. Censuses. Men and women are defined as financially independent if they are in the labor force; however, because women in 1960 rarely combined full-time work and motherhood, married full-time mothers are also counted as financially independent in both

Background/Literature

- Young Adults live with parents longer
  - Some 57% of 20-22 year olds, including 74% of four-year college students, lived with their parents in 2002-2003, an increase of 11% since 1985
  - ~1/2 of those who move out move back home
- Parents provide more financial support to young adult children
  - 2/3 of young adults in early 20s and 40% in late 20s receive financial help from parents
  - 1/2 of parents 45-55 years old have an adult child living with them
- Inequality and parental help
  - Parents in top ¼ of income distribution gave 70% more in financial support than bottom ¼.
- Varied experiences and exposure based on diverse cultural, ethnic and racial backgrounds
- 30% of all young adults 18-34 in the U.S. are children of immigrants

Methods

- Based on interviews conducted from 2000-2004, consisting of 462 participants all in their 20s and 30s through the Research Network on Transitions to Adulthood Qualitative Study
- Subsample consisted of 30 interviews ages 20-34, 15 men and 15 women equally distributed among the following groups: US-born Whites and African Americans, Russian Jews, Dominicans, and West Indies
- Primary focus is to examine the diverse subsample of these young adults' interviews, paying particular attention to their perceptions of the role their families play in their transition to adulthood
- In coding these interview transcripts there were 3 main themes identified: financial/housing support, racial inequality and family formation



Quotes

"I moved back in with my family… always did help on payments, like the light bill, also on the phone bill, my food"
-- West Indian male 22

"Right now its not economical for me to move out and live on my own …gives me an opportunity to save money"
--White female, 26

"I guess its not in my culture to push you know, to get away from my mother and push her away for my own life and my own family…it wouldn't be realistic, for her do all that she has done for me so that I can attain what she couldn't attain"
-- West Indian female 28

Results

Family Support in Young Adulthood:

- **U.S.-born Whites and Blacks:** Live with parents and receive financial help
  - Are saving money, not paying bills and are unlikely to give help to parents
- **Immigrants:** Live with parents, both receive and give financial help to family
  - Contribute to household by paying family bill such as rent, electric bill, etc.

Culture: narrative differences

- **U.S-born Whites and Blacks:** focus on the way to own independence
- **Immigrants:** focus on their obligations to their families as well their own achievement for families' well being

Racial Inequality:

- **Immigrant/U.S-born Blacks:** discussed struggles due to race
- **Immigrant/U.S-born Whites:** did not see race as an issue

Family Formation:

- **Immigrant/U.S-born Blacks:** non-marital birth is acceptable/fairly common and the large proportion of this subsample already had children.
- **Immigrant/U.S-born Whites:** tend to delay family formation in the forms of marriage, partnership, and child birth

Discussions and Implications

- Delayed transition to adulthood has been seen across different cultures and family backgrounds
- More than any other time in our history, parents are being called on to provide financial assistance to grown children
- However, some parents of adult children are in a better position to help than others—reproducing social inequalities
- More research is needed in this area with a particular focus on immigrant experiences
- Institutions like colleges/universities *should* better prepare and provide resources to these young adults to ease the transition into the workforce

References

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Pictures retrieved from: NY Times (August 3, 2003), Google (7/26/12), Zazzle.com